

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

A new government took shape with the Commons away

A government was rebuilt this week, and the House that is supposed to watch it do so was not there. Andy Burnham completed his ministerial appointments on Thursday 23 July, four days after taking office: John Healey moved from Defence to the Treasury; Rachel Reeves left the Chancellorship rather than accept another post; David Lammy was dismissed as Deputy Prime Minister, and no Deputy Prime Minister was appointed to replace him, Louise Haigh instead taking the older title of First Secretary of State

alongside the Duchy of Lancaster. Fifteen ministers went in all. Whole departments went with them — Science, Innovation and Technology abolished outright, Business renamed and widened to swallow science and trade, Culture, Media and Sport re-constituted, and a new Office for the Prime Minister and Cabinet raised at the centre. In the Commons, none of this was said aloud. Not one division; not one written question tabled. The Lords took two more days about rising, sitting on the twenty-second and the twenty-third, and on the twenty-

second the National Security (State Threats) Bill quietly received Royal Assent. Meanwhile 221 written answers arrived, fifty-two of them from Defence, replies to questions put to a government that in several cases no longer exists in the form addressed. And tomorrow, more than two million people in Greater Manchester vote for the mayoralty Burnham had to give up to sit in the Commons at all — the largest by-election this country has held. The House itself returns on 1 September.

BURNHAM COMPLETES HIS MINISTERIAL APPOINTMENTS
Thursday 23 July. The new Prime Minister took office on 20 July and his cabinet first met on the twenty-first. The full slate of ministers was finished on the twenty-third, inside this window. John Healey moved from Defence to become Chancellor of the Exchequer. Rachel Reeves left the Treasury after reportedly declining another post.

NO DEPUTY PRIME MINISTER IS APPOINTED
Thursday 23 July. David Lammy was dismissed as Deputy Prime Minister and Justice Secretary, and the office was left vacant. Louise Haigh instead holds the older title of First Secretary of State, together with the Chancellorship of the Duchy of Lancaster. She is the deputy in everything but name.

BURNHAM'S GOVERNMENT
Appointments completed on 23 July. The four great offices and the First Secretary of State are shown first. There is no Deputy Prime Minister; the office was left vacant and Louise Haigh holds the older title instead.

Andy Burnham PRIME MINISTER	John Healey CHANCELLOR OF THE EXCHEQUER	Ed Miliband FOREIGN SECRETARY
Shabana Mahmood HOME SECRETARY	Louise Haigh FIRST SECRETARY OF STATE	
Defence	Wes Streeting Environment, Food and Rural Affairs	Dame Angela Eagle
Health and Social Care	Yvette Cooper Northern Ireland	Sir Chris Bryant
Justice, Lord Chancellor	Alex Norris Scotland	Douglas Alexander
Education	Lucy Powell Wales	Stephen Kinnock
Work and Pensions	Pat McFadden Leader of the Commons	Sir Alan Campbell
Business, Innovation, Science and Trade	Jonathan Reynolds Leader of the Lords	Baroness Smith of Basildon
Housing, Communities and Local Government	Angela Rayner Chief Whip	Anneliese Midgley
Transport	Heidi Alexander Women and Equalities	Bridget Phillipson
Energy Security and Net Zero	Miatta Fahnbulleh Chief Secretary to the Treasury	Emma Reynolds
Digital, Culture, Media and Sport	Lisa Nandy Attorney General	Ellie Reeves

THE WEEK IN BRIEF
Departments are abolished, renamed and recreated, Across the window. Science, Innovation and Technology was abolished. Business was renamed and widened to cover business, innovation, science and trade. Digital, Culture, Media and Sport was re-constituted. A new Office for the Prime Minister and Cabinet was established at the centre. Fifteen ministers departed in total.

Greater Manchester votes for a new mayor, Thursday 30 July. Burnham had to give up the mayoralty to take his seat. A mayor of a combined authority holding police and crime commissioner powers is disqualified on becoming a Member of Parliament, and he became one by winning the Makerfield by-election. Paul Dennett has been acting mayor and is not standing. Bev Craig stands for Labour and Co-operative against six others, including Reform UK, the Greens, the Conservatives and the Liberal Democrats. The electorate is above two million, the largest by-election Britain has held.

National Security (State Threats) Act 2026 receives Royal Assent, Wednesday 22 July. The bill completed its passage and became an Act on the first day of this window. It was the last piece of legislation to finish before both Houses had gone.

The Lords sits for two more days, Wednesday 22 and Thursday 23 July. The upper House held eleven chamber items on the Wednesday and nine on the Thursday. For those two days it was the only House working. It gave second readings to bills on sporting events, on microplastic filters in washing machines, on restoring powers to the Youth Justice Board, on creative education access, and on co-operative capital.

221 written answers arrive with nobody to receive them, Across the window. Departments cleared answers to questions tabled before the rise. Defence sent fifty-two, Housing forty-two and Education thirty-eight. Some were addressed to departments since renamed or abolished. None can be pressed further until the autumn.

When Parliament comes back, Tuesday 1 September. The summer recess runs to 31 August and the Commons returns the following day. There was no Prime Minister's Questions in either week of this window. The first session of the new administration falls six weeks into the job.

THE FEATURE
A government rebuilt without a chamber to answer to
Machinery of government changes usually arrive with a statement. A department is abolished, another is created, and a minister comes to the despatch box to explain who now answers for what. That did not happen this week and could not have.

The Commons rose on 16 July, before the change of Prime Minister, and does not return until 1 September. So the new shape of government was settled in writing, over six weeks, with no urgent question and no chance to press a minister on where a responsibility has gone. The questions answered this week were written to departments that in some cases no longer exist under those names. The first real accounting falls on 1 September.

THE RECORD
Every figure checked against the official Parliament record. Compiled from the Official Report, the written question record and the division lists, and rendered to one sheet for the week.